DAY 30 GUIDE

OpenAI Presence for Startups

How to choose, design, pilot, and scale a trusted AI agent for customer and internal workflows. Written for beginners. No jargon, no fluff.

WHAT YOU WILL GET

A practical framework to pick the right workflow, define policies and permissions, prepare your data, test safely, measure results, and decide whether to pursue Presence or prototype first.

IMPORTANT REALITY CHECK

OpenAI describes Presence as an **enterprise product** delivered with OpenAI Forward Deployed Engineers or selected partners. It is not a self-serve tool you can sign up for today. But that is not a reason to skip this guide: early-stage startups can prepare the workflow and prototype the same agent foundations **before** contacting sales. That preparation is exactly what this guide covers. [1][2][3]

STEP 01 UNDERSTAND THE PRODUCT

What OpenAI Presence actually is

Before you evaluate any tool, get clear on what it does. In plain words:

Presence helps companies deploy **trusted AI agents** across voice and chat. These agents can answer questions, resolve issues, use company systems, take approved actions, and escalate to a person when needed. [1]

Think of it as a trained team member, not a chat widget. It follows your rules, works inside your tools, and knows when to hand a case to a human.

THE FOUR THINGS A PRESENCE-STYLE AGENT DOES

UNDERSTAND
Interprets open-ended customer or employee requests, even when people phrase them badly.

ACT
Uses connected systems (CRM, billing, ticketing) and performs only the actions you approve.

FOLLOW POLICY
Applies your SOPs, permissions, guardrails, and escalation rules on every conversation.

IMPROVE
Uses production conversations, evaluations, and approved updates to get better over time.

PRESENCE VS A NORMAL CHATBOT

DIMENSION	NORMAL FAQ CHATBOT	PRESENCE-STYLE AGENT
Purpose	Answer common questions	Complete a defined workflow end to end
Company systems	Usually limited or none	Reads and updates approved systems
Actions	Mostly text responses	Can take approved actions (refund, update, create)
Control	Prompt-level rules	Policies, permissions, guardrails, evaluations, escalation
Human handoff	Basic transfer	Designed escalation paths and approvals

BEGINNER TAKEAWAY

A chatbot talks. An agent completes work. The entire value of Presence comes from that difference, and everything in this guide is about setting up an agent to complete work **safely**.

STEP 02 FIND THE RIGHT USE CASE

Choose one workflow, not "an AI agent"

The most common beginner mistake is asking for "an AI agent for our company." OpenAI recommends starting with one specific job. The agent should receive only the knowledge and system access required for that job. [1]

A GOOD FIRST WORKFLOW HAS FOUR SIGNALS

- ✓ **It happens often.** Volume is what makes automation worth it.
- ✓ **The steps are mostly repeatable.** Same shape of problem, again and again.
- ✓ **Policies or SOPs already exist.** The agent needs written rules to follow.
- ✓ **Success and failure can be measured.** If you cannot measure it, you cannot trust it.

FIVE PRACTICAL STARTUP USE CASES

1. **CUSTOMER SUPPORT**
   Resolve common billing, order, subscription, delivery, or account questions. Escalate the exceptions.
2. **LEAD QUALIFICATION**
   Respond instantly, understand intent, ask qualifying questions, capture details, and update the CRM.
3. **EMPLOYEE HELP DESK**
   Answer leave, payroll, expenses, onboarding, equipment, and account-access questions.
4. **IT SUPPORT**
   Handle password resets, access requests, software guidance, and route complex incidents.
5. **OPERATIONS INTAKE**
   Collect supplier, procurement, claims, or service-request information and move it to approval.

DO NOT START HERE

- × A first pilot that must handle **every** customer issue.
- × An agent that makes irreversible financial decisions.

STEP 03 DESIGN THE WORKFLOW

The 7-part agent blueprint

Answer these seven questions and you have designed your agent, even before touching any technology. Write your answers down. You will reuse them in Step 04.

1

JOB

What exact outcome must the agent complete? Example: resolve standard subscription cancellations.

2

CHANNEL

Where will the conversation happen: voice, web chat, app, or an internal workspace?

3

KNOWLEDGE

Which approved sources can it use: SOPs, help center, product data, customer records?

4

TOOLS

Which systems can it read or update: CRM, billing, ticketing, identity, inventory?

5

POLICIES

What rules must it follow? What must it never say or do?

6

APPROVALS

Which actions are automatic, which need human approval, and which are blocked entirely?

7

ESCALATION

When and how should it hand the case to a person, with full context preserved?

THE SIMPLEST TECHNICAL MODEL

Strip away the buzzwords and a reliable agent needs only three foundations: a **model** for reasoning, **tools** for retrieving information or taking actions, and explicit **instructions and guardrails**. Everything else is built on top of these three. [3]

BEGINNER TAKEAWAY

Notice that five of the seven blueprint parts are about **control**: knowledge limits, tool limits,

STEP 04 SCOPE YOUR PILOT

The discovery worksheet

Fill this before contacting a builder, partner, or the OpenAI sales team. One clear page is worth more than a vague "we need an AI chatbot" request. Print this page or copy the questions.

1 · WORKFLOW NAME
Example: subscription cancellation support

2 · PRIMARY USER
Who starts the conversation?

3 · TRIGGER
What event or request begins the workflow?

4 · SUCCESSFUL OUTCOME
What must be true when the workflow is complete?

5 · KNOWLEDGE SOURCES
List approved documents, databases, and records.

6 · READ PERMISSIONS
What information may the agent retrieve?

7 · ACTION PERMISSIONS
What may it update, send, approve, refund, cancel, or create?

8 · HUMAN APPROVALS
Which actions require a person to confirm first?

STEP 05 BUILD AND TEST

A realistic 30-day pilot plan

One month, four phases. Each week has a single goal, so you always know whether you are on track.

Week 1
Define

- → Choose one workflow. Just one.
- → Collect policies, SOPs, examples, and edge cases.
- → Write the permission and escalation matrix.
- → Capture current baseline metrics so you can prove improvement later.

Week 2
Prototype

- → Connect only the minimum knowledge and tools.
- → Test normal cases, ambiguous requests, and failures.
- → Review outputs with the people who currently do the job.
- → Create a small evaluation set of real scenarios.

Week 3
Controlled launch

- → Release to a limited audience or a small slice of traffic.
- → Require approval for risky actions.
- → Log every tool call, escalation, and failure.
- → Give users a clear path to a human at all times.

Week 4
Evaluate, improve

- → Measure resolution, quality, handoffs, and policy compliance.
- → Fix instructions, data gaps, permissions, and tooling.
- → Expand only when targets are consistently met.
- → Document every approved change.

BUILD SMALL FIRST

OpenAI's agent guidance recommends an incremental approach: start with a single agent and a limited tool set, validate with real users, then add complexity only when the workflow requires it. [3]

STEP 06 PROVE VALUE AND CONTROL RISK

Measure it like a business system

An agent is not "done" when it launches. It earns trust through numbers. Track these eight metrics from day one.

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Resolution rate	Percentage of eligible cases completed correctly.
Human handoff rate	How often the agent escalates, and whether it escalates at the right time.
First-contact resolution	Cases solved without a repeat contact.
Time to resolution	Median time from request to completed outcome.
Policy adherence	Percentage of interactions that follow required rules and approvals.
Tool accuracy	Correct system, correct fields, correct action, correct record.
Satisfaction	Customer or employee feedback after the interaction.
Cost per resolved case	Total operating cost divided by successful resolutions.

A USEFUL BENCHMARK, NOT A PROMISE

OpenAI reports that Presence now resolves **75% of inbound issues** on its English-language phone support channel without human assistance, and that an improvement loop reduced human handoffs by **15 percentage points in 10 days**. Your results will depend on workflow, data, tools, policies, and testing. [1][2]

SEVEN COMMON FAILURE MODES

- × The workflow is too broad or poorly defined.
- × The source of truth is outdated, conflicting, or inaccessible.
- × The agent has more permissions than the job requires.
- × There is no clear approval or escalation path.
- × Testing covers only ideal conversations.
- × The team launches across every channel before proving one.
- × Success is measured by "messages answered" instead of outcomes completed correctly.

STEP 07 CHOOSE THE RIGHT PATH

Your next move

You now understand the product, the use cases, the blueprint, the pilot, and the metrics. Three paths forward, pick the one that matches where you are.

PATH A

Pursue OpenAI Presence

Best for an organization with a high-value workflow, clear policies, required system integrations, measurable volume, and the ability to work with OpenAI or an approved partner. Prepare the worksheet from Step 04 before contacting sales.

PATH B

Prototype the workflow first

Use the same foundations described in OpenAI's agent guidance: model, tools, instructions, guardrails, evaluations, and human handoffs. Start with a narrow single-agent prototype and prove the workflow before expanding. [3]

PATH C

Scope a custom implementation

Need help translating your workflow into a custom AI agent, dashboard, automation, or internal tool? Submit the requirement at **servana.co.in**. Servana is independent from OpenAI Presence and does not imply Presence access or affiliation.

THE ONE-SENTENCE BRIEF · COPY THIS

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We want an AI agent that helps [user type] complete [specific workflow]
through [voice/chat], using [approved knowledge] and [systems], while
following [policies], requesting approval for [actions], and escalating when
[conditions].
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OFFICIAL SOURCES

[1] Introducing OpenAI Presence · openai.com/index/introducing-openai-presence

[2] OpenAI Presence for Business · openai.com/business/openai-presence

[3] A practical guide to building agents · openai.com/business/guides-and-resources/a-practical-guide-to-building-ai-agents